comprised only 6–9 per cent of the region's total population of about 600,000 people.[4] While disregarding such demographic facts, Bialik and Herzl accorded great importance to mythology, most notably the stories of the Bible, without which modern Zionism is unimaginable. Bialik and Herzl were also influenced by the nationalist myths that were created in the nineteenth century by almost every other ethnic group in Europe. The Ukrainian Jew Bialik and the Hungarian Jew Herzl did for Zionism what was earlier done by the poets Taras Shevchenko for Ukrainian nationalism,[5] Sándor Petőfi for Hungarian nationalism[6] and Adam Mickiewicz for Polish nationalism.[7] Observing the growth of other national movements all around, Herzl wrote that nations arise 'out of dreams, songs, fantasies'.[8]

But dreams, songs and fantasies, however inspiring, are not enough to create a functioning nation-state. Bialik inspired generations of Jewish fighters, but to equip and maintain an army, it is also necessary to raise taxes and buy guns. Herzl's utopian book laid the foundations for the city of Tel Aviv, but to keep the city going, it was also necessary to dig a sewage system. When all is said and done, the essence of patriotism isn't reciting stirring poems about the beauty of the motherland, and it certainly isn't making hate-filled speeches against foreigners and minorities. Rather, patriotism means paying your taxes so that people on the other side of the country also enjoy the benefit of a sewage system, as well as security, education and health care.

To manage all these services and raise the necessary taxes, enormous amounts of information need to be collected, stored and processed: information about properties, payments, exemptions, discounts, debts, inventories, shipments, budgets, bills and salaries. This, however, is not the kind of information that can be turned into a memorable poem or a captivating myth. Instead, tax records come in the shape of various types of lists, ranging from a simple item-by-item record to more elaborate tables and spreadsheets. No matter how intricate these data sets may become, they eschew narrative in favor of dryly listing amounts owed and amounts paid. Poets can afford to ignore such mundane facts, but tax collectors cannot.

Lists are crucial not only for national taxation systems but also for almost all other complex financial institutions. Corporations, banks and stock markets cannot exist without them. A church, a university or a library that